The Pillowman

By Martin McDonagh

PAGE 25 - 30

TUPOLSKI: What happened to the third child? Andrea Jovacovic. You know who she was?

KATURIAN: *(pause)* Only from the papers. She was the girl they found on the heath.

TUPOLSKI: She was the girl they found on the heath, yes. You know how she died?

KATURIAN: No. The papers didn't say.

TUPOLSKI: You know who Aaron Goldberg was? He was the boy they found in the dump behind the Jewish quarter. You know how he died?

KATURIAN: No. The papers didn't say.

TUPOLSKI: *(mocking)* No, the papers didn't say. They papers didn't say a lot of things. The papers didn't say anything about the third child, a little mute girl, went missing three days ago, the same area, the same age.

KATURIAN: What did my brother say to you? Whatever he said, you made him say. He doesn't speak to strangers. I want to see him. I've got a right to see my brother! *(crying)* I just write stories! I don't understand a thing of what's going on!

TUPOLSKI: No? Well, here's where we stand. Along with the evidence we found in your house, your brother has, under duress or not, admitted enough about the killings for us to execute him before the evening's out. But, he's hardly the brains behind the operation, so we want you to confess too. We like executing writers. Dimwits we can execute any day. And we do. But, you execute a writer, it sends out a signal, y'know? *(Pause)* It sends out the

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signal 'DON'T . . . GO . . AROUND . . . KILLING . . . LITTLE . . . KIDS.' *(Pause)* Where's the mute girl?

KATURIAN: *(pause)* I've listened to your bullshit for a long time now, and I want to tell you a couple of things. . . I don't believe my brother said a word to you. I believe that you are trying to frame us for two reasons. One, because you don't like the kind of stories I write, and two, because you don't like retarded people cluttering up your streets.

INTRODUCTION

In The Pillowman by Martin McDonagh, a writer is interrogated about the gruesome content of his short stories and their similarities to a number of child-murders that are happening in his town. He learns that his older brother, Michal, is also being held and questioned in another cell. Michal, who has the mind of a child. Michal, who our author, Katurian, has raised ever since the death of their parents.

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PAGE 36 – 67

A cell. Michal is listening to the intermittent screams of his brother, Katurian, being tortured a room away. Michal mimics them till they fade way. Michal's cell is unbolted and the bloody, breathless Katurian is thrown in. Michal looks over Katurian, who is shivering on the floor, goes to caress his head, can't quite do it.

MICHAL: Hiya. You were making some racket. What were they doing, torturing ya?

KATURIAN: Did yours hurt? When they tortured you?

MICHAL: They didn't torture me. *(Katurian looks him over for the first time, seeing there are no cuts or bruises)* Oh, no, the man said he was going to torture me, but I thought, 'No way, boy, that'd hurt,' so I just told him whatever he wanted to hear, and he was fine then.

KATURIAN: *(pause)* Swear to me on your life that you didn't kill those three kids.

MICHAL: I swear to you on my life that I didn't kill those three kids. *(Katurian breathes a sign of relief)*

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KATURIAN: The only thing they've got against us is what you've said, and the stuff they said they found in the house. Oh my God. Whatever they do, Michal, no matter what, you don't sign anything. You got it?

MICHAL: Whatever they do to me, I don't sign anything. *(Pause)* Can I sign your name?

KATURIAN: Especially don't sign my name.

MICHAL: 'I killed a loda kids,' signed Katurian Katurian. Hah! 'And it was nothing to do with his brother, Michal, not even a bit,' Hah!

KATURIAN: *(Pause)* We'll be alright, Michal. We'll be alright. We'll get out of here. If we just stick together.

MICHAL: Tell us a story, Katurian. It'll take my mind off . . .

KATURIAN: What story do you want?

MICHAL: Do 'The Pillowman'.

KATURIAN: *(Pause)* Once upon a time . . . there was a man, who did not look like normal men. He was about nine feet tall . . . *(Michal looks up, silently whistles)* And he was all made up of these fluffy pink pillows: Even his head was a pillow, a big round pillow.

MICHAL: A circular pillow – I prefer ' a ***circular*** pillow'.

KATURIAN: His head was a circular pillow. And on his head he had two button eyes and a big smiley mouth.

MICHAL: Do your mouth smiley like the Pillowman's mouth is. *(Katurian gives a big dopey smile)*

KATURIAN: Well, the Pillowman had to look like this, he had to look soft and safe, because of his job, because his job was a very sad and a very difficult one . .

MICHAL: Uh-oh, here it comes . . .

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KATURIAN: Whenever a man or a lady was very very sad because they'd had a dreadful and hard life and they just wanted to take their own lives by razor, or by bullet, or by gas, or . . .

MICHAL: Or by jumping off of something big.

KATURIAN: Yes. Just as that person was about to do it, the Pillowman would go to them, and sit with them, and gently hold them, and he'd say, 'Hold on a minute,' and time would slow strangely. The Pillowman would go back in time to when that man or that lady was just a little boy or a little girl, to when the life of horror they were to lead hadn't quite yet begun, and the Pillowman's job was very very sad, because the Pillowman's job was to get that child to kill themselves.

MICHAL: Um, could you skip on to the end, please? This bit's a bit boring.

KATURIAN: Well, that's a bit rude, Michal, actually.

MICHAL; Oh, Sorry, Katurian. *(Pause)* But could you skip on to the end, please?

KATURIAN: *(Pause)* Well . . . the end of the Pillowman . . . See, when the Pillowman was successful in his work, a little child would die. And when the Pillowman was unsuccessful, a little child would have a horrific life, grow into an adult who'd also have a horrific life, and ***then*** die horrifically. He decided to do just one final job and that'd be it. So he went to this place beside this pretty stream that he remembered from a time before . . .

MICHAL: I like this bit . . .

KATURIAN: And he brought a little can of petrol with him, and he sat and he waited there a while. There was a little caravan nearby, and the Pillowman heard the door open and little footsteps come out. It was a little Pillowboy. And the Pillowman told him all about his sad job and the dead kids and all that type of stuff. And the little Pillowboy understood instantly, and he poured the can of petrol all over himself. And the Pillowboy struck a match, and the

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Pillowman sat there watching him burn. And as the Pillowman gently started to fade away, the last thing he saw was the Pillowboy's happy smiley mouth as it slowly melted away. The last thing he heard was the screams of the hundred thousand children he'd helped to commit suicide coming back to life and going on to lead the cold, wretched lives that were destined to them because he hadn't been around to prevent them.

MICHAL: *(Pause)* So the Pillowman just faded away? Ah.

KATURIAN: Into the air. Into Heaven.

MICHAL: I like the Pillomwman. He's my favourite. *(Thinking)* Hmmm. I still can't figure it out.

KATURIAN: Figure what out? Figure out 'The Pillowman'?

MICHAL: No, I thought I'd hidden it really well.

KATURIAN: Hidden what really well?

MICHAEL: The box with the little boy's toes in it. They must've used sniffer dogs or something. Because, no, way, I hid them brilliant. Christmas tree pot. You only see it once a year.

KATURIAN: You just told me you didn't touch those kids. You just lied to me.

MICHAL: No I didn't. I just told you the man came in and said he'd torture me unless I said I killed those kids, so I said I killed those kids. That don't mean I didn't kill those kids. I did kill those kids.

KATURIAN: You swore to me, on your life, that you didn't kill those three kids.

MICHAL: Ohhh. See with that one, yeah, I was kind of playing a trick on ya. Sorry, Katurian. I know it was wrong. Really, But it was very interesting. The little boy was just like you said it'd be [in your story, The Tale of the Town on the River] I chopped his toes off and he didn't scream at all. His name was Aaron. God, he bled a lot. You wouldn't've thought there'd be that much blood in such a little boy. Then he stopped bleeding and went blue. I feel

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quite bad now, he seemed quite nice. But the girl was a pain in the *ass*. Kept bawling her eyes out. And she wouldn't eat them. She wouldn't eat the applemen, and I'd spent ***ages*** making them. It's really hard to get the razor blades inside. You don't say how to make them in [that] story, do ya? I checked. So, anyway, I had to force 'em down her. It only took two. Not being mean, but at least that shut her up.

KATURIAN: *(Realization has finally dawned –quietly)* What did you do it for?

MICHAL: Don't cry, Katurian. Don't cry. You know. Because you told me to.

KATURIAN: *(pause)* I remember telling to your do your homework on time. I remember telling you to brush your teeth every night . . . I don't remember telling you to take a bunch of little kids and go butcher them!

MICHAL: I didn't butcher them. ."Butcher them' it'd be more like . . . *(Michal imitates viciously hacking at someone.)* Mine was more like . . . *(Michael imitates a gentle, single hack onto imaginary toes, then delicately throwing the tows away.)* And . . . *(Michal imitates placing two applemen inside a little mouth, then swallowing)* And I wouldn't have done anything if you hadn't told me, so don't you act all the innocent. Every story you tell me, something horrible happens to somebody. I was just testing out how far-fetched they were. *(Pause)* D'you know what? They ain't all that far-fetched.

KATURIAN: You're a sadistic, retarded pervert who ***enjoys*** killing little kids!

MICHAL: *(Pause)* I ***didn't*** enjoy killing those kids. It was irritating. It took ages. And I didn't ***set out*** to kill those kids. I just set out to chop the toes off one of them and to put razors down the throat of one of them.

KATURIAN: Are you telling me you don't know that if you chop the toes off a little boy and put razors down the throat of a little girl, you don't know that they're gonna die?

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MICHAL: Well, I know now! *(Katurian puts his head in his hands, trying to think of a way out of this).* Well, the torture man certainly seemed to be on my side. He seemed to agree it was all your fault. [That] all the things I did to all the kids I got from stories you wrote and read out to me.

KATURIAN: That isn't the truth, Michal.

MICHAL: Yes it is. ***Did*** you write some stories with children getting murdered in them?

KATURIAN: Yes, but . . .

MICHAL: Well, ***did*** you read them out to me?

KATURIAN: Yes . . .

MICHAL: Well, ***did*** I go out and murder a bunch of children? *(Pause)* 'Yes, I did,' is the answer to that one. So I don't see how the 'That isn't the truth' comes into it. I mean, you're my brother and I love you, but y'know, you've just [been] telling me a story about a bloke, his main thing in life's is to get a bunch of little kids to set themselves on fire, so y'know? And he's the hero! I'm not criticizing. He's a very good character. He reminds me a lot of me – You know, getting little children to die. All that.

KATURIAN: The Pillowman never killed anybody, Michal. And all the children that died were going to lead horrible lives anyway.

MICHAL: You're right, all children are going to lead horrible lives. You may as well save them the hassle.

KATURIAN: Not all children are going to lead horrible lives.

MICHAL: Erm, hmmm. Did you lead a horrible life since you was a child? Yes. Erm, did I lead a horrible life since I was a child. Yes. That's two out of two for a start.

KATURIAN: They're going to execute us in an hour and a half. They're going to destroy us, they're going to destroy my stories.

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MICHAL: Well, I think it's us we should be worrying about, Katurian, not your stories. They're just paper.

KATURIAN: *(barely containing he anger)* If they came to me right now and said, "We're going to burn two out of the three of you, you, your brother, or your stories,' I'd have them burn you first, I'd have them burn me second, and I'd have it be the stories they saved.

MICHAL: You're just like Mum and Dad!

KATURIAN: *(Laughing)* ***I'm*** just like Mum and Dad? Let me work this out . . . Mum and Dad kept their first-born son in a room where they tortured him for seven straight years, and you made a little boy bleed to death, made a little girl choke to death, and God knows what to another little girl and ***you're not*** like Mum and Dad?

MICHAL: I'm not like them. I didn't want to hurt anybody. I was just doing your stories.

KATURIAN: What did you do to the third girl?

MICHAL: *(long pause)* When I was in here listening to you screaming next door, I thought this musta been kinda like how it was for you all those years. Well, let me tell ya, it's easier from this side.

KATURIAN: I know it is.

MICHAL: You only had it for an hour and you came in *whining* your snotty head off. Try it for a lifetime.

KATURIAN: That doesn't excuse anything.

MICHAL: It excused the two ***you*** murdered. Why shouldn't it excuse the two I murdered?

KATURIAN: I murdered two people who tortured a child for seven years. You murdered three children who hadn't tortured anybody for any years. There's a

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difference. . . How did you kill the third girl, Michal? I just need to know. Was she like in a story too? Which story was she like?

MICHAL: You're gonna be mad. Like, um . . . she was like in um . . . 'The Little Jesus'. 'The Little Jesus'. *(Katurian looks at Michael, hands to his face and, as he pictures the horrific details of the story, he slowly starts to cry.)* Will they execute us together or separate? I hope it's together. I wouldn't wanna be on my own.

KATURIAN: ***I*** haven't ***done*** anything!

MICHAEL: At least we'll be together in Heaven, whatever happens. And hang out with God.

KATURIAN: Which particular Heaven is this you're going to Michal? Child-killer Heaven? Do you want to know where you're going when you die? You're going to go to a little room in a little house in a little forest, and for the rest of all time you're going to be looked after not by me, but by a person called Mum and a person called Dad, and they're gonna look after you in the same way they always looked after you, except this time I'm not gonna be around to rescue you, 'cos I ain't going to the same place you're going, 'cos I never butchered any little kids . . .

MICHAL: That is just the most meanest thing that any person has ever said to any other person.

KATURIAN: I used to love you so much.

MICHAL: *(pause)* What do you mean, 'used to'? *(Long silence)*

KATURIAN: Right at this moment, I don't care if they kill me. I don't care. But they're not going to kill my stories. They're all I've got. The three stories you chose to act out just happened to be the three most repulsive stories you could've chosen to act out. They weren't the first three you happened to come across, they were the three that most suited your repulsive little mind.

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MICHAL: So, what, I could've done ones that wouldn't've been so horrible? Like what? Like 'The Face Basement'? Slice off their face, keep it in a jar on top of a dummy, downstairs? They're all sick. You couldn't've picked one that wouldn't've been just as sick.

KATURIAN: Why did it have to be 'The Little Jesus', though?

MICHAL: Tell me a story. Tell me the one about the little green pig.

KATURIAN: *(pause)* I can't remember how it goes, 'The Little Green Pig' . . . *(remembering)* Okay. Settle down *(Michael does so with a pillow beside his head)* Once upon a time, on a farm in a strange land far way. . .

MICHAL: Far away . . .

KATURIAN: There lived a little pig who was different from all the other pigs around.

MICHAL: He was green.

KATURIAN: Are you telling this story or am I? Are we interrupting or are we listening and sleeping?

MICHAL: You. Sorry. Fingers on lips. Shhh. Listening and sleeping.

KATURIAN: Good. *(pantomimes telling the rest of the story as Michael falls asleep. Katurian looks at Michael and realizes he is asleep – and finishes the story in a whisper)* . . . he knew that he was still, and he always would be, just a little bit peculiar . . . *(Pause)* You like that one, don't you Michal? You used to like that one. No little toes in it . . . no razor blades in it. *(Pause)* It's not your fault, Michal. *(Crying)* I'll be coming along soon. *(Katurian takes the pillow and holds it down forcefully over Michal's face. Michal starts to jerk. After a minute Michal's jerks lessen. He's dead. Katurian takes the pillow off, kisses Michal, crying , he closes Michal's eyes. He goes to the door, clangs it loudly)* Detective?! *(Pause)* Detective?! I would like to make a confession to my part in the murders of six people. *(Pause)* I have one condition. *(Pause)* It involves my stories . . .

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